

## Pinochet's repressive urbanism: the violent neoliberalisation of space in Santiago

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According to recent findings compiled by researchers Patricio Bustamante and Ricardo Moyano, the city of Santiago was founded over an Inca settlement, whose layout would coincide with that of Pedro de Valdivia ordering the Alarife Gamboa, following the urban design regulations established in the Laws of the Indies set by the Spanish Crown. Perhaps the main difference between the Inca and Spanish layout is the economic objective that motivated the Valdivian urban design. The fact is that Santiago was founded, then, on two dispossession operations: land privatisation and distribution of those plots among the Valdivian hosts to start the productive enterprise, and the crushing and appropriation of the pre-existing Inca layout for the development of the colonial installation in Chile.

Crushing and privatising to produce is what will trigger a long history of spatial violence driven by the pursuit of wealth and class distinction. Since the origins of Chile as we know it, the land has been the object of exploitation and rent on which a large part of the wealth of the elites has been built. In these processes, urbanism (in its archaic colonial forms until its scientific formulation in 1932) has been the instrument to organise the urban space, and with that, has organized the way of relating in society. Chilean urbanism has been subjected to ideological construction, as a representation of the way the elites understand the social space: a source of wealth. Whether following the plans of Pedro de Gamboa, Benjamín Vicuña Mackenna, Karl Brünner or Arnold Harberger, the urban space of Santiago has been constantly rethought and organised for the benefit of a *rentist* interpretation of the

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city, optimising its exchange value, subjugating- the use-value and configuring a spatially ordered mechanism for social control. This chapter exposes what the Pinochet government did in the city of Santiago to advance the understanding of the neoliberal dictatorial urbanism that shaped today's metropolis.

City theorist Bernard Tschumi<sup>2</sup>, argues that there are no spatial transformations without the exercise of violence, given that the act of changing the forms of the city implies destroying the previously existing ones. For his part, Eyal Weizman states that the urban form can exercise a mode of violence that develops slowly: architecture and the built environment are a type of slow violence. The occupation of an environment that was conceived to strangle Palestinian communities, cities and neighbourhoods, to generate unliveable conditions for people<sup>3</sup>. Weizman uses for his theory the territorial conflicts in Gaza, realising how effectively urbanism can develop repressive faculties through its practice, separating Israelis from Palestinians, generating areas of destruction and areas of defence, spaces of life and spaces of survival. Repressive urbanism, like all urban models, can be objects of design, of social strategies and,- consequently, of political action.

The forms of violence of the Chilean dictatorship also had their urban representation. Given the neoliberal nature of the Pinochet regime, and the eagerness to repress in favour of carrying forward the free-market revolution, cities like Santiago are marked by the forensic footprints of a repressive urbanism, which is expressed in socio-spatial segregation, metropolitan fragmentation, the gentrification of entire neighbourhoods and the ethical transformation of urban disciplines, which in order to survive under a neoliberal regime, it had to abandon their search for the good city - the just city, to finally surrender to the logic

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<sup>2</sup> Bernard Tschumi, 'Violence of Architecture' [1981] A vol. 20 numb 1, 44-47.

<sup>3</sup> Eyal Weizman 'The architecture of violence' (Al Jazeera English, 29 June 2014), <http://www.aljazeera.com/programmes/rebelarchitecture/2014/06/architecture-violence-2014629113556647744.html> Accessed 2nd May 2017

of the city as a source of profit<sup>4</sup>. Whether as a neoliberal phenomenon according to Alfredo and Paula Rodríguez<sup>5</sup> or as an exemplary metropolis for Latin America according to Glaeser and Meyer<sup>6</sup>, Santiago had to experience an initial phase of reorganisation of the space to activate the commodification of the urban elements<sup>7</sup>.

This chapter will serve to explain how and why the dictatorship exercised its repressive urbanism in favour of organising a city like Santiago for profit. In a first section, a brief explanation of the indissoluble dependence of the neoliberal model of urban development is presented, to then expose the way in which in the Chilean case the transformations that allowed the development of the neoliberal city were carried out, pointing out how this urbanism jeopardised the collective conception of the city in favour of an elite centred in the maximization of profits. I was interested in focusing on the violation of article 25 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights<sup>8</sup>, to take advantage of the audience of this book, as an invitation to understand that our cities, as living beings and representations of the social relationships<sup>9</sup>, have also suffered humiliation and torture, which have not been stopped. These vexations are spatial, expressed in exploited territories that determine the greater or lesser access to the benefits of living in a city, applying the logic of inclusion and exclusion, segregating the inhabitants into communes according to their purchasing power.

It will be important to expose the value of the struggle for the right to the city, a political way to struggle against the repressive urbanism inherited from a fierce dictatorship

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<sup>4</sup> Vergara-Perucich, José-Francisco. *Urban design under neoliberalism: theorising from Santiago* (Routledge, 2019).

<sup>5</sup> Rodríguez, Alfredo, and Paula Rodríguez, *Santiago, una ciudad neoliberal* (primera edición, Olacchi 2009).

<sup>6</sup> Glaeser, Edward Ludwig, and John Robert Meyer., *Chile: political economy of urban development* (Harvard University Press 2002)

<sup>7</sup> Henri Lefebvre, 'La producción del espacio' (Capitán Swing, 2013)

<sup>8</sup> Everyone has the right to a standard of living adequate for the health and well-being of himself and of his family, including food, clothing, housing and medical care and necessary social services, and the right to security in the event of unemployment, sickness, disability, widowhood, old age or other lack of livelihood in circumstances beyond his control.

<sup>9</sup> Lefebvre (n 1).-

that continues to be present in the ways of organizing our cities in the present, with obsolete planning instruments that facilitate the transformation of urban products into commodities for financial speculation, following neoliberal land management guidelines and with a tremendous power concentrated in business groups that have understood the city as a source of wealth, crushing the remote possibility of discussing again the social role of the land, and avoiding that urban centres, nowadays, are vital for the development of life in the context of climate crisis. All this was at the heart of the Pinochet government's urban policies.

#### A brief explanation of the city as a source of wealth

Those unfamiliar with terminology and urban theory may have a simpler understanding of the city: a space in which we all live and develop our activities. This is true, although there is also a second layer of information in the city, another way of using it: for capital accumulation through the production of long-term fixed-income assets and, consequently, as a source of wealth fundamental for financial investments in order to increase its value on time. Post-industrial capitalism has made important advances that are reflected in substantial gains for those --who have the resources to invest in certain specific economic factors. Moreover, with the irruption of the global system of information and business flows. What is certain is that this advance has gone very fast and the flows are increasingly efficient. Faced with this vortex, the speed at which capital reproduces itself often crashes against various barriers that hinder its fluid circulation and slow its expansion, which also obstructs the much-desired growth.

What is complex for the expectations of making capital grow is that these barriers have not yet been breached, given the global interdependence of markets between different

nations and their -own internal instabilities, specific geopolitical variables, changes in the supply of labour, and a long etcetera on the problems inherent in economic relations in a global society. The problem is that, by taking away the fluidity of circulation, capitalists can face a contradiction by not being able to develop their processes of capital accumulation because of what may be understood as institutional constraints (democratic laws, for instance). Before facing potential stagnation, capital begins to lose profitability. That is the moment when the city and the processes of urbanisation come to the rescue of capitalism from its own contradictions. As David Harvey explains: In periods when the economy shows excessive growth, capital is withdrawn from other sectors and introduced into everything that is related to real estate, urbanisation, and so on. When other economic sectors are regularised, capitals are reintroduced in other places.<sup>10</sup> It is important to underline that capitalism in its neoliberal form depends not only on the market and the State playing a role as an economic facilitator, but also on space, on urbanisation processes. With this in mind, when capitalism is reviewed, it is no longer possible to look only to it as a series of abstract r-elational factors such as financial assets (subject to periodic fluctuations and crises), given that it is in the city where modern capitalism materialises its profits, giving a concrete body to its processes, manifesting itself in physical form, visible, palpable and, of course, tradeable.

According to David Harvey<sup>11</sup>, urbanisation and military expenditures are the main capital goods available to the capitalist to absorb the surplus of his production, maintaining stable profitability in the long term for the capital they invest. In the particular case of Santiago, this absorption has been developed through the real estate market. Investment in construction generates many jobs (always desirable by governments to reduce

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10 Lefebvre (2013) 221.

11 David Harvey 'Rebel Cities'(London: Verso 2012)

unemployment), generates sales for large sums of money, which through credit incorporates the bank in the acquisition of long-term debtors (whether builders or homebuyers), and creates a type of spatial-capital that rarely devalues over time. For example, in Santiago, house prices have been rising steadily since 1984<sup>12</sup>. This implies that investment in the construction and sale of real estate ensures that the return on capital will hardly fail to increase in value over time and will rarely fall below the initial investment. However, for these certainties to occur, both the economic regulations and the urban fabric must comply with certain characteristics. For now, in the business of the city, the most important matter is to ensure that the properties are well-organised and located, near centralities or in exclusive neighbourhoods.

The general criterion to determine a prospection of the values of urban product is the centrality of its location, which is explained by the theory of central places. The positivist urban localisation theories of the neoclassical urban economy state that the centrality of a real estate defines a large part of its value. By centrality is understood both its proximity to urban spaces where sources of work and services are concentrated, as well as the accessibility that one has to reach those sources of work. For example, access to the Metro, to large avenues, transport corridors, to mention a few examples that increase the value of the real estate business. These principles are based on the theory of the central places of Walter Christaller, who in 1933 proposed that the points where the main services for people are located (work, market, leisure) make up centralities from which a radius of influence can be traced that hierarchizes the value of properties. While prominent econometrists such as Masahisa Fujita, Paul Krugman and Anthony Venables have relativized that Christaller's criterion is the mantra for the location in the city, the truth is that the evidence indicates that

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<sup>12</sup> Databases of El Mercurio newspaper since 1979, measuring the annual variation of the price of the sale of new apartments in Santiago, using values passed to UF according to evaluated year..

in the case of Santiago the theory well applies to the way in which the dictatorship sought to organize the city for the real estate capital and as a consequence a transfer is observed from the centre of Santiago to central spaces of the high neighbourhood of the city (Examples: Barrio El Golf and Nueva Las Condes). This is what I will deepen it in the next paragraphs.

However, in the 70s, real estate developers would need -as usual- the help of the State to install their capitalist reproduction machinery on the metropolitan space of Santiago. In those years, large plots of urban land close to centralities were occupied by informal settlements whose dwellers were waiting until 1973 for housing solutions. These settlements had arisen due to the very failures of the Chilean capitalist system; and although the governments of Alessandri, Frei and Allende had advanced in the development of public policies of urban improvement -and in the particular case of Frei and Allende with important levels of materialization of solutions (Table 1 and Graph 1)-, the dictatorship did not hesitate to dismantle the urban planning apparatus and impose ideologically solutions coming from the neoliberal theoretical framework, using public funds to begin to more decisively promote private action through the mechanism of demand subsidies. The slums represented a severe headache for Pinochet, given that since 1957 they arose as an impugnation of the sacrosanct right to private property, a situation that was supported by influential politicians and by the Catholic- Church through the Hogar de Cristo<sup>13</sup> and since the promulgation of the 1980 Constitution, this right will be defended by the State with all the necessary physical and institutional force and violence. However, these spaces in seizure were also opportunities to implement the mechanism of subsidy for the acquisition and sale of housing, encouraging the development of private real estate companies. Moreover, given the important social organization required to maintain and manage the slums, for Pinochet these socially active spaces represented an imminent danger of politicization, therefore it was not

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<sup>13</sup> Vicente Espinoza. 'Par\*a una historia de los pobres en la ciudad' (Ediciones Sur 1988).

only necessary to re-move people from these strategic sectors for economic development, but also to divide them and impede the much-feared social engagement of the grassroots (which in any case would follow its course, and with more force). Then, the urban apparatus of repression of the dictatorship will appear, with all its neoliberal creativity and using the armed arm of the State to carry out a true cleansing of the profitable urban land.

Table 1: Number of dwellings delivered by sector. Source: Own elaboration based on Kusnetzoff 1987.

| Year | Public housing | Private housing |
|------|----------------|-----------------|
| 1964 | 6938           | 12902           |
| 1965 | 37514          | 15054           |
| 1966 | 13433          | 14328           |
| 1967 | 28285          | 16653           |
| 1968 | 32730          | 19683           |
| 1969 | 14460          | 23310           |
| 1970 | 5914           | 17792           |
| 1971 | 76079          | 10893           |
| 1972 | 20312          | 13752           |
| 1973 | 20877          | 14484           |
| 1974 | 3297           | 17084           |
| 1975 | 3750           | 12740           |
| 1976 | 24022          | 11519           |
| 1977 | 14057          | 9455            |
| 1978 | 4118           | 17371           |
| 1979 | 329            | 33480           |
| 1980 | 1846           | 41721           |
| 1981 | 589            | 49268           |
| 1982 | 436            | 23825           |
| -    |                |                 |



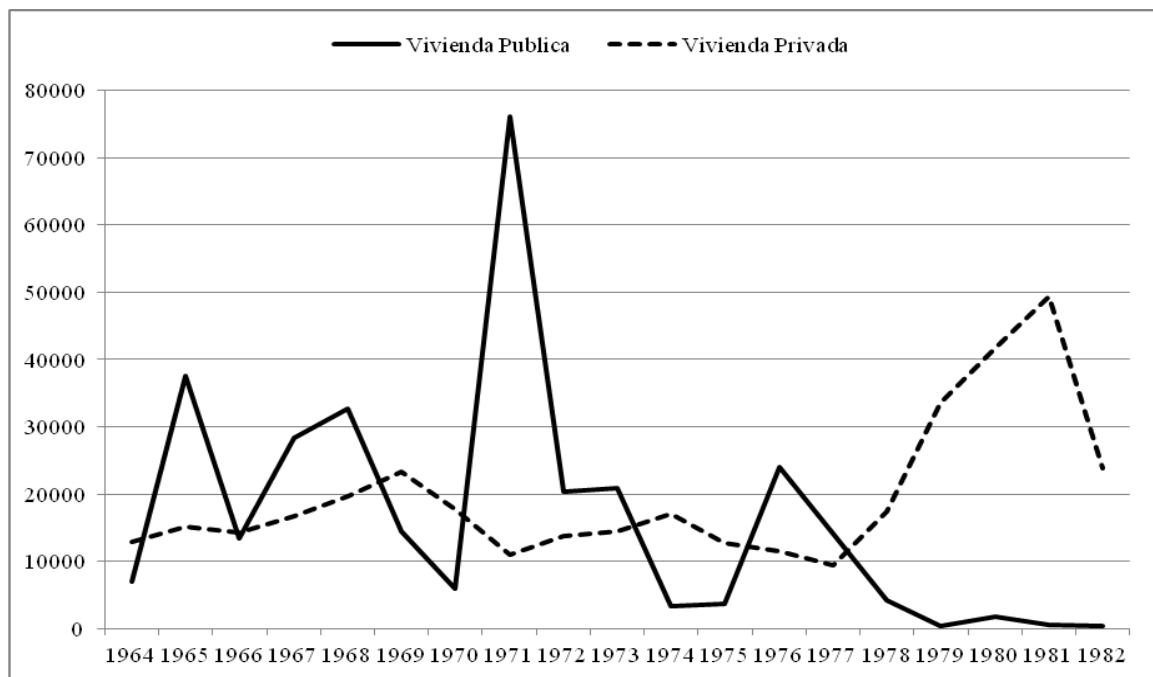


Figure 1: Amount of public housing per year. It is evident that there was a radical change in the fiscal contribution to the housing problem when the neoliberalisation of the State began in 1975. Source: Own elaboration based on Kusnetzoff 1987.

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## --Repressive urbanism and neoliberalisation in Santiago

An informative poster developed by the Vicariate of Solidarity of 1982 indicated: "Chilean, don't be frightened, let's defend our citizens' rights"<sup>14</sup>; and then explain what, in the event of the police breaking-in a home, should be applied to articles 4 and 5 of the 1980

Constitution, which stated: "No. 4 Respect for and protection of private and public life and the honour of the individual and his family; No. 5 The inviolability of the home and of all forms of private communication (...)"<sup>15</sup>; together with the invocation of article 12 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights on the right to protection before the law against arbitrary attacks on persons. The instruction gave an account of the growing process of repression of which the inhabitants were victims after the promulgation of Pinochet's Constitution. However, the repressive urban process began much earlier, with fraternity operations in the late 1970s, as discussed later in this section. For the Chilean case, and in the particular elaboration of this essay, the first approximation to repressive urbanism is developed by Antonio Cassese in 1978<sup>16</sup>. Cassese explains that since the first years of the dictatorship the price of housing increased dramatically, reaching 534% in 1974<sup>17</sup> which was problematic for 20% of the population who lacked adequate housing. Cassese indicates that between 1978 and 1987, a number of 1,262,735 houses should have been built based on the deficit, a situation that was not fulfilled and by 1990 the transition to democracy would begin with a deficit of 1,030,828 houses<sup>18</sup>. The dictatorship's response to the deficit will be developed following a neoliberal approach, seeking to maximize the profitability of inv-

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<sup>14</sup> Vicaría de la Solidaridad. '¿Qué hacer en caso de allanamiento en la población?' (1978 . Available at Archivos Nacionales, Biblioteca Nacional de Chile 1982)

<sup>15</sup> Vicaría de la solidaridad (1982).

<sup>16</sup> Antonio Cassese 'Estudio del impacto de la ayuda y asistencia económica extranjera en el respeto de los derechos humanos en Chile' (Consejo Económico y Social de las Naciones Unidas 1978).

<sup>17</sup> Cassese (1978) 217.

<sup>18</sup> Joan Mac Donald 'Aún faltan 888 mil viviendas en el país'. (El Mercurio, 19 June 1994)

estments in private hands and using the opportunity of the enormous deficit as an excuse to invest in projects of public interest.

The urban fabric of Santiago in the first years of the dictatorship was full of conflicts typical of the spatial history of this city (a spatialised class struggle), which during the middle of the 20th century had developed into a democratic boom and the strengthening of a promising welfare state in the context of Latin America. The configuration of this city did not respond to the new patterns of the state-citizenship relationship imposed by the governing board: depoliticisation of society, elimination of democracy and militarisation of public space. In the face of this distance between the dictatorial project and social reality, the disciplinary form of repressive urbanism emerged. Projecting a theoretical definition, repressive urbanism consists in the exercise of the organization of the functions, spatiality and administration of the city, starting from a series of imposed measures of transformation which to be implemented required the force of the repressive apparatus of the State; either - by means of police force, military or, in a less visible manner but more durable, by means of public policies with objectives of social control from the configuration of space. The objective of repressive urbanism will be to discipline the city -both its citizens and its urban order- in favour of fulfilling the expectations of a hegemonic class, without having to face democratic processes, of public impugnation to the measures or simple opposition to the facts in exercise. A clear example of repressive urbanism was Haussmann's remodelling of Paris, where the Parisian authorities removed all the dispossessed classes from the centre, placed them in the periphery and reconfigured a complete city in favour of the embellishment, functionality and social control of space. Repressive urbanism in Santiago was expressed both institutionally (as public policy and market organisation) and spatially (as repressive acts and market operations).

-Institutionalised instruments of spatial repression: the dictatorship's urban development policies

In relation to institutional matters, the main tool to maintain the reproduction of repressive urbanism's socio-spatial effects was composed by the national urban development policies of 1979 and then 1985, both tending to monopolise urban development based on market objectives, minimising the democratic role of the city and leaving the State as a mere facilitator of private initiatives. The National Urban Development Policy of 1979 <sup>19</sup>(PNDU 1979) is theoretically justified by an article written by Arnold Harberger, who raises the importance of removing urban boundaries in order to increase the amount of land available for housing development and thus increase its supply and reduce its price. This with the aim of reducing the housing deficit and improving the prospects of the housing market. Harberger will argue that all major cities had gone through -major territorial expansion<sup>20</sup>. However, Harberger will omit that the city of Santiago was not yet dense enough and that existing levels of urban poverty did not make it pertinent to conduct longstanding urban experiments that would tend to hand over all the power of urban development to the market. This will be ignored by the urban advisors of the Pinochet regime and in 1979 the PNDU was formulated. This policy defined that land was not a scarce resource, that urban development must be controlled for its profitability and that land use must be defined according to market requirements, appealing to the completely flawed interpretation of Adam Smith's invisible hand. The only role attributed to the State will be to

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<sup>19</sup> MINVU - Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo 'Hacia una nueva política urbana para Chile: Antecedentes históricos'. (Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo, Programa de las Naciones Unidas para el Desarrollo, 2013).

<sup>20</sup> Arnold Harberger, 'Notas sobre los problemas de vivienda y planificación de la ciudad' (AUCAN 37, 1979)

protect the common good, without detailing what that common good was<sup>21</sup>. With this policy, 64,000 hectares were added to the urban area of Santiago, which at that time had an area of less than 42,000 hectares<sup>22</sup>. According to Amador Brieva<sup>23</sup>:

"The Policy was approved in March 1979, but its implementation was reduced since although it postulated modifying or replacing the general norms of urbanism and construction, it did not materialise. Where it did find its full materialisation was in the Metropolitan Region, through the issuance of Legislative Decree No. 420 of 1979, which expanded the urban area of Greater Santiago, adding about 64,000 hectares to the urban area. This measure meant lifting the restriction imposed by the urban limit on Santiago's growth, effectively increasing the potential supply of urban land, which facilitated the emergence of new urban areas in the rural area. Although this incorporation of land towards a New Urban Policy in Chile was intended to lower the price of the land. However, the opposite happened and the price increased by 200%." <sup>24</sup>

Criticism of the measure was not long in coming. In 1981, Pablo Trivelli wrote a didactic article explaining the aberrant reality of the results of the 1979 PNDU<sup>25</sup>. Trivelli exposed how complicated it is to generate a regime of land competition when the city and urban development are fundamental to implement public policy programs of general interest to society. Conversely, the 1979 PNDU would simplify the complexities of the urban land market, bringing it to the level of any other type of consumer good, applying a utopian approach to the search for improved land supply. Precisely, while the policy sought to

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21 In: Gimenez, P., Gazitua, G. (de.) (2012) *Hacia una política Nacional de Desarrollo Urbano: Antecedentes Históricos*. Volumen 1. Santiago: LOM Ediciones.

22 Database of Ducci y González in Galetovich & Poduje 2006.

23 In Giménez & Gazitúa 2012.

24 Brieva in MINVU 2013, 12-13.

25 Pablo Trivelli, 'Reflexiones en torno a la política nacional de desarrollo urbano', (EURE. Revista - Latinoamericana de Estudios Urbanos Regionales. Vol 8 N° 22, 1981).

reduce the price of land to make it more accessible to the poorest people, the effect was exactly the opposite. For Trivelli, the annulment of the State as a public planning apparatus will be a serious mistake in the long term: "In a context of rapid economic growth and with a persistent process of concentration of the population in urban areas and, in particular, in the Metropolitan Area of Santiago, these policy decisions added to the liberalization of taxes on urban land (...) and the recovery of construction activity, instead of curbing speculation, have stimulated it".<sup>26</sup> Trivelli emphasises the clearest evidence of the speculative bias of the -1979 PNDU, the absence of an objective city image. Since the market has controlled urban development in Chile, the spatiality of the city, the urban future we are building, has been almost eliminated by political agendas. Urban design (the art of shaping cities) was replaced by large-scale architecture (large objects over the city) or by pro-business urbanism<sup>27</sup> to generate urban products and not to create a city. For all this, the repressive urbanism in its political form will have a great responsibility.

For its part, the problem of the incipient financing of the housing market was deeply described by Francisco Donoso and Francisco Sabatini in 1980. The results of their research, showed that the financial investments had turned to the land market as they ensured high rates of return by incurring low risks. They conclude that "the increase in the sale price of a square meter built at 5.27 U.F. is the result, first, of a greater real estate profit of between 2.97 and 4.43 UF. and, only secondarily, of an increase in costs (between 0.84 and 2.30 UF.)"<sup>28</sup>. It would be a turn in the way of managing the soil and with it would appear the power of the owner imposing a speculative model. The authors determine that these new variables in the land market will have a profound effect on the increase in residential segregation, largely because groups with greater purchasing power will have the possibility

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26 Trivelli, P. 1981, p. 58.

27 López-Morales, Gasic Klett, Meza Corvalán (2012)

28 In Donoso & Sabatini 1980, p. 31.

of concentrating in specific areas of the city (eastern sector) and that the price of land will allow the inhabitants of other classes to be displaced to communes according to their income level.<sup>29</sup> Specifically, Donoso and Sabatini's research will allow us to understand that Pinochet's repressive urbanism tended to create a city model where high-income families will be able to choose where to consolidate their concentration spaces, segmenting the city according to purchasing power and leaving urban spaces of poorer quality (and therefore lower price) for the working classes. However, to carry out these operations of the reorganization of the city, it will be necessary to move masses of low- and middle-income population embedded in the urban areas desired by the richer classes, so it will be necessary in this a State action to facilitate this transformation.

Faced with these aberrant results, the dictatorship will have to correct its errors and change its policy for the cities, given the overwhelming evidence related to the potential failure of the proposed urban model in the long term, and for its effects absolutely contrary to its objectives. As in so many other cases, the dictatorial experiment with Chilean society will fail based on its initial objectives (this urban model can be added to other examples such as the AFP, the privatization of education and health), and Pinochet will try to correct the problems caused by the first national urban development policy, through the PNDU 1985<sup>30</sup>, which will be called the Adjusted Policy, replacing that of 1979. Salvador Valdés, member of the team that drafted the new policy, will recognise that many of the institutions needed to solve the problem of urban development in Chile could not be included in this n-

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29 "This process of residential, commercial and employment segregation of high-income groups - which would have been accentuated from 1974 onwards according to the fourth hypothesis - is, to a large extent, promoted and capitalised by the large development and real estate companies in their projects. Given their income, these groups have the option not only of buying a luxury home, but also the possibility of segregating, with respect to other social groups, their places of residence, services and, to a certain extent, work.." Donoso & Sabatini Op. Cit., p. 45.

<sup>30</sup> MINVU (2013).

ew policy since there was no political consensus with the authorities.<sup>31</sup> Nor, admits Valdés, was it possible to incorporate the new aspects discussed in this policy to the General Law of Urbanism and Constructions. Finally, the document operates only as a guide and no legal instrument changed its condition until its repeal in 2000. In this way, although the guidelines will increase the attributions of the State to regulate the land market, in concrete terms, everything will remain in the hands of a self-regulated free-market political economy of the city.

#### The practice spatial repression: The eradications under the dictatorship

From the perspective of the urban form, the main action of the dictatorship in Santiago was the processes of eradication of populations of scarce resources and their relocation to the periphery of Santiago. When reviewing this history, it is fundamental to - refer to the *Operation of Confraternity*, consisting of the relocation of inhabitants of scarce resources from the communes of Las Condes, Santiago and La Reina, to communes such as La Granja, San Bernardo and Puente Alto. Under the excuse of "providing aid to the most dispossessed"<sup>32</sup> and thus move toward "making Chile a country of owners, not of proletarians."<sup>33</sup>, as Pinochet himself promulgated. The main goal of these eradication processes is to restore the right to private property by sanctioning the political action of impugnation composed of the taking of land (common political practice between 1957 and 1973) and cleaning the urban land with good location for the development of real estate

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31 "The constitutionality of Urban Development was an aspect that had to be excluded from the Policy. State action in this area includes numerous ministries, affects dozens of laws, and compromises the attributions of politicians and civil servants who are generally not inclined to cede part of their faculties. Modifying that substantially exceeded the scope of the Working Group, and there was no political consensus to support administrative changes of this magnitude." Valdés in Giménez & Gazitúa (2012), p. 38.

32 In: Jornadas del Presidente de la Republica (1979). p. 13. (full citation)

33 "El Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo a los Pobladores de Campamentos y a la opinión pública en general" [Newspaper insert]. *El Mercurio* (Santiago, 27th July 1980). In: Silva Salinas 2012.



projects. For Eduardo Morales and Sergio Rojas, it was possible to carry out a deep cleaning from the communes of the eastern sector, to relocate the population in communes that over the years would consolidate a spatial class bias <sup>34</sup>(see table 2). This reorganisation of the social fabric of the city, in turn, will shape the application of a market strategy to the organisation of urban land: the segmentation of the land market, creating communes for the rich, middle class and poor, thus facilitating the allocation of urban products, social policies and control mechanisms.

Table 2. Origin and destination of eradications under dictatorship (number of families).

| Commune       | Displaced | Established | Home income 1990 in UF | Home income 2013 in UF | Variation 1990-2013 |
|---------------|-----------|-------------|------------------------|------------------------|---------------------|
| La Granja     | 1392      | 8519        | 18,15                  | 27,45                  | 51%                 |
| Pudahuel      | 2435      | 3826        | 19,64                  | 29,89                  | 52%                 |
| Renca         | 1077      | 3564        | 18,85                  | 33,76                  | 79%                 |
| Puente Alto   | 326       | 2936        | 25,13                  | 31,83                  | 27%                 |
| San Bernardo  | 623       | 2065        | 28,83                  | 29,55                  | 2%                  |
| *-Maipú       | 2075      | 2002        | 33,84                  | 44,13                  | 30%                 |
| Ñuñoa         | 1771      | 1741        | 67,75                  | 100,50                 | 48%                 |
| La Cisterna   | 1542      | 1149        | 20,53                  | 47,88                  | 133%                |
| San Miguel    | 1865      | 1000        | 30,18                  | 53,21                  | 76%                 |
| Quilicura     | 731       | 560         | 20,09                  | 48,84                  | 143%                |
| La Florida    | 2871      | 400         | 31,77                  | 44,37                  | 40%                 |
| Conchalí      | 1544      | 305         | 27,62                  | 29,13                  | 5%                  |
| La Reina      | 874       | 120         | 68,50                  | 101,28                 | 48%                 |
| Quinta Normal | 627       | 0           | 22,03                  | 36,50                  | 66%                 |
| Providencia   | 205       | 0           | 96,00                  | 101,04                 | 5%                  |
| Las Condes    | 2511      | 0           | 97,12                  | 117,27                 | 21%                 |
| Santiago      | 2823      | 0           | 25,36                  | 61,33                  | 142%                |
| Áreas Rurales | 3595      | 701         | 17,11                  | 34,62                  | 102%                |
| TOTAL         | 28887     | 28887       |                        |                        |                     |

Source: based on Hidalgo 2005 and CASEN 2013.

<sup>34</sup> Eduardo Morales and Sergio Rojas, 'Relocalización socio-espacial de la pobreza: política estatal y presión popular, 1979 – 1985. (FLACSO 1986).

Between 1976 and 1987, 28,887 families were taken to military trucks and moved out to live in the communes that corresponded to them depending on their purchasing power. At the beginning, in these new lands where they were moved out, the dictatorship promised a decent house, but it never arrived. Instead, the only materialisation of this promise was a set of sanitary huts arranged on rural lands, without public transport and services, only precarious constructions. In Santiago alone, more than 100,000 people were displaced. The march of military trucks through the city corresponded to the violent act of territorially displacing people to be relocated in places in accordance with the objectives of a hegemonic class that saw in the land market a fruitful field to sow its seeds of profitability and thus ensure the obtaining of fixed income in the long term. All this was possible mainly due to the protection of private property enshrined in the constitution of 1980 which together with the right to free enterprise will configure a new urban form, individualistic, fragmented, segregated and permanent. Repressive urbanism will be the action of the State tending to con-figure the neoliberal urbanism that is solid, enduring, profitable and builds over the spatial distinction of classes. As table 3 indicates, the segmentation of the city allowed to focus the urban development, going from the investment in more central communes or of greater interest for the investors, towards the communes that were near the urban centralities, with the socio-space effects previously mentioned. Today Santiago is the most segregated city among the members of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD), followed by London and Budapest<sup>35</sup>, and of a total of 36 nations analysed, Chile ranks 33rd in quality of housing. While the city has suffered from these phenomena, the real estate business has yielded important returns becoming one of the most

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35 Chile marks a SIGMA of 0.55, while London marks 0.49 and Budapest 0.47. OCDE 2013, p. 58.

profitable ways to produce long-term fixed-income<sup>36</sup>. From this perspective, the city as a financial asset fulfils its mission at the expense of the population.

Table 3. Variations in the balance between sales value and construction costs per year.

| Year | Sale value | Building cost | Sale value-costs | Return on Investment (Gross) |
|------|------------|---------------|------------------|------------------------------|
| Año  | UF/m2      | UF/m2         | UF               | %                            |
| 1975 | 11,44      | 3,76          | 7,68             | 204 %                        |
| 1980 | 14,51      | 11,65         | 2,85             | 24%                          |
| 1985 | 14,20      | 12,29         | 1,91             | 16%                          |
| 1989 | 15,30      | 13,10         | 2,20             | 17%                          |
| 1993 | 17,62      | 13,73         | 3,89             | 28%                          |
| 2000 | 20,25      | 14,82         | 5,43             | 37%                          |
| 2005 | 23,80      | 15,74         | 8,06             | 51%                          |
| 2010 | 33,10      | 14,97         | 18,13            | 121%                         |
| 2016 | 49,66      | 15,22         | 34,44            | 226%                         |

Source: \*-Own elaboration based on the price of land in Greater Santiago per year built based on sales publications in El Mercurio newspaper and data from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Development on reference costs of construction price for buildings type D category 1, which corresponds to the highest category for housing.

In 1982, Santiago's political administration changed from having 15 to 32 communes, one of the largest metropolitan areas in Latin America in terms of the number of adjacent autonomous administrative divisions, without a central authority (mayor) with the powers to carry out comprehensive coordination among the communes. In other words, each commune will operate with high levels of autonomy, obligated to self-finance and generate its own ordinances of territorial regulation embodied in a communal regulatory plan. This model is ideal for reproducing the standards of living in each commune. Under the logic of self-financing and decisional autonomy, rich communes will be able to perpetuate their

<sup>36</sup> Vergara-Percich, José-Francisco, Aguirre-Núñez, Carlos. Inversionistificación en América Latina: problematización del mercado de arriendo para el caso chileno (Habitat y Sociedad. Vol. 1. Num. 12, 2019\*).

wealth-y standards, protect their lands from the creation of poverty ghettos and generate standards of living that will be highly superior to those of poor communes that, on the other hand, having to self-finance, will be constantly operating with balances close to zero.

With these measures, Pinochet revived the segregated desires of Benjamín Vicuña Mackenna in 1872, who raised the need to separate civilised citizens from barbarism, in order to make the *lowborn people* be educated based on the example of a superior social class in customs, culture and abilities.<sup>37</sup> Territorial dominance and the exclusion of the poor from the benefits of urban life have always been a shameful engine of urban development in Chile. The oligarchy has configured public policies to defend its property (source of all wealth in a pure rentier and extractivist Chile), for which it has not hesitated to use the full force of the State and its forceful arms to defend the model. Vicuña Mackenna's repressive proto-urbanism, which was not materialised, revived in the eaves of a ferocious dictatorship whose association with the oligarchy would allow private property order to be restored, strengthen the reproductive possibilities of the oligarchic class and build an appropriate space to perpetuate this process of spatial subjugation.

## Conclusions

This chapter has sought to highlight the immanent existence of a theory on repressive urbanism in the history of neoliberal spatial transformations in Chile. This, taking as an example the case of Santiago, from the institutional perspective and the actions of the transformation of space based on violence. As a hypothesis, this chapter raises the need to deepen the theorisation of repressive urbanism as a bridge for the installation of neoliberal

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<sup>37</sup> Benjamin Vicuña Mackenna, 'La transformación de Santiago' (Bookstore Printing of EL Mercurio 1872).

urbanism. In my view, the second could not exist without the first. The accelerated neoliberalisation of urban development in Chile could obey a very effective policy of urban violence from the State, repressing potential insurrections against private property using all possible force. A mode of shock therapy in the urban context.

The absolute commodification of land and the neoliberalisation of urban disciplines are a vital factor in the struggle to strip today's Chile of its dictatorial legacies, whose hiddenness can only be explained by the participation of diverse political actors in the land market. Without going any further, in the declaration of interests of the congressmen, it can be seen that 21 out of 38 senators declare to have investment companies that have participated in the purchase and sale of properties. On the other hand, there is a significant concentration of political and business power in the Chilean Chamber of Construction (C.Ch.C.). Of the 10 most important economic groups in the country, 10 participate as active members of the C.Ch.C. In addition, it is enough to review the agendas of the ministries of public works and housing to see how systematically the authorities of the Chilean Chamber of Construction have direct access to ministers and undersecretaries, but not associations of residents or groups that seek to transform the neoliberal logics that govern our model of urban development. Furthermore, the CChC has a direct incidence in the design of urban policies, posing the contradiction in which the regulated proposes and validates the rules that will regulate them.

However, a door has opened: The social outburst of October 2019 is reclaiming the city, they demand spatial justice and for doing so, the social movements is organically reorganising the way we understand the city of Santiago as a whole. The results of these changes are uncertain yet, but the new political scenario is expected to reach a more democratic approach to urban design, in which the community and welfare are more relevant than profitability and the private property. In any case, the outburst may be seen as

a demand to put an end to the torture of cities by the market rules and the state as a passive accomplice of the urban atrocities of segregation, displacement, gentrification and exclusion from urban life.

Finally, a reflection for those who are not accustomed to seeing the city as an object of study. Housing is fundamental for the development of life; without housing it is practically impossible to survive. This is ratified by the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. The fact that housing is only in private hands constitutes a dangerous bet, where the possibilities of configuring monopolies or oligopolies could harm society as a whole. This is the case of Chile, where the Chilean Chamber of Construction oligopolically organises the market as a gigantic lobby organisation for the sake of real estate business. On the other hand, the State has preferred to leave everything in the hands of the private sector, without assuming its role as an articulating agent of society, as a coordinator of problems in relation to seeking the common good. The passivity of the state has been scandalous so far, even when compared to other neoliberal contexts such as European countries or even in some North American states. The clearest example is that the price of housing in Santiago is not set based on fierce competition between companies, but is set based on expectations of profit from the investment. This condition originates mainly because housing is basic to the development of life (such as water, health or education), a population in constant demographic growth assures its demand. Traditionally, the prices of goods and services are set by striking a balance between what companies are willing to pay and what customers are willing to pay. However, in the case of housing, clients (or citizens) cannot stop paying for housing, since there are no assets in addition to their use-value.

De-neoliberalising the land and housing market is essential to end another of the effects of the Chilean dictatorship, to turn from repressive urbanism to a democratic urbanism, once and for all.